Silverheights School Council Meeting Minutes

Date & Time: April 26, 2023, 6:30-8:30 pm (virtual only)

"Parents play a vital role in the development and education of their children and in the success of schools.
They are the most important influence in a child's life outside of school.
Long after direct learning from parents in a child's early years gives way to formal education, parents continue to play a key role in student success through the attitudes they help to share and the direct supports they provide."

Ontario Ministry of Education

School Council Summary: https://www.wrdsb.ca/our-schools/get-involved/school-councils/

School Council Handbook: https://www.wrdsb.ca/wp-content/uploads/school_council_chairpersons_handbook.pdf

Item	Agenda Item	Duration	Person(s) Responsible
1	**Welcome & Introduction** - Attendees: Alison C, Erin A, Treasure K, L. Tam, Sandy (SNA), Amy P., Tara G., Chad M. - Approval of March Meeting Minutes by email	5 mins	Chair (Ling Tam)
2	**News** Community Partnership – Silverheights Neighbourhood Association - www.silverheightsneighnourhood.com Summer Camp registration opens this Saturday March 25th at 9:00 am, registration will be done online only, but if you need assistance you can call the centre or email We are now accepting LIT applications for summer camp volunteers 13+ if interested please email Kathleen@silverheightsneighbourhood.com We are collecting dresses and suits for prom and graduations for youth in our community. We will be collecting until April 21st and then scheduling appoints to come and "shop" the clothes on April 29th. We will also be giving gift cards for dry cleaning and alterations. June 10 Neighbourhood Day held on the tarmac at the St. Gabrial's school. Mid-afternoon. See website for event details.	5 mins	Community Rep (Sandy)
	WRAPSC – see attached	5 mins	Assembly Rep (Amy Pharoah)
3	**Teacher's Report** - Jump Rope for Heart today (Apr 26) - Intermurals (badminton, soccer) - Earth Day activities - Science Fair activities, 15 selected to go to regionals, 3 won awards.	10 mins	Teacher Rep (C. Moffat)

	- Ace club coffee cart continues - In-school clubs continuing (D&D, chess, Rainbow) - Autism awareness day this week. - Gr. 8 planning end of year trip – Proposal provided to admin for consideration.		
4	**Principal's Report** - Impressed with Gr. 8 end of year trip proposal. Process of putting this together has been very well developed & engaged with the students. Student voting last week. Results of the polling to be announced soon.. - Some ideas were consolidated based on logistical considerations so some students felt their expectations were not being held - Class field trips planned & teachers wish list being crossed off. - EQAO pending for Gr 3 & 6 students - Looking for financial support for year-end celebrations (Estimated = $6000). Google form for voting pending confirmation of costs - Leveled reading resources (Syllasense JK-Gr3, $5,600 for levelled reading kits)	10 mins	Principal (Jason Stere, regrets; Tara Goudy)
5	**Equity Connection**	5 min	Vice-Principal (Tara Goudy)
6	**Financial Report** April Run date Balance = $21,822 Grants: https://www.wrdsb.ca/wp-content/uploads/4690-School-Generated-Funds.pdf PIC Grant - received Parents Reaching Out (PRO) Grant: Applied & Awarded! 5 Students leading the Words Matter (Microaggression) discussions in the Gr 7/8 classes. Discussion in 2 sessions (identifying & what to do). Students to received t-shirts paid for by grant.	10 min	Treasurer
7	**Council Subcommittees** Pizza Committee Debrief	15 mins	Subcommittee Rep

Pizza Week #	Week	Pizza Slice Totals
1	Jan. 24	635 slices
2	Feb. 7	647 slices
3	Feb. 14	736 slices
4	Feb. 21	785 slices
5	Feb. 28	792 slices
6	Mar. 7	748 slices
7	Mar. 21	812 slices
8	Mar. 28	790 slices
9	Apr. 4	643 slices
10	Apr. 11	803 slices
11	Apr. 18	812 slices
12	Apr. 25	894 slices

Total of 12 events held thus far
7 events pending through Jun 13
If funds remain from “giving” option, potential for a free pizza day.
Parent volunteers going well. Noticed some parents are double-purchasing slices. Parents with police checks from other organizations can be forwarded to the office. Class map to be provided.

Fundraising Committee

- Smencil sales – leftover supply in the school. Could this be used as a Gr. 8 fundraiser? Can they be engaged to give them agency for organization/sales under volunteer adult supervision?

Special Event initiatives

- Kindie Welcome Event (Jun 15, 5:45 to 7pm) – banner needs to be ordered. Leah to be engaged as a professional graphic designer. Needs to be quoted ASAP. Do we need to use a board-approved vendor?

Options:

- Family movie nights
- Community Activity Fair
  General inbox has been receiving emails from various community extra curricular activities. Consider restarting plans to host a community activity far?

9	**Calendar of Planned School Events** - Weekly Pizza Days - Kindie Night June 15	5 min	Council Members

	- Gr. 8 Celebration TBD - September Meet the Teacher Event?		
10	**New Items** - Student Volunteer Opportunities – see attached (Amy) - BrainGym Youth Scholership Program: (https://msha.ke/braingymkw) - See attached volunteer opportunities to be shared on School Day	5 min	Council Members
11	Questions & Answer Period Sibling Photo Day – runners will pick up the older sibling who will then go pickup the younger sibling to bring to the gym Spirit Wear orders complete. Delivery by end of this week.	5 mins	Council Members
12	Next Meeting Date:	May 24, 2023	In-person & online meet
13	Agenda Items for Next Meeting - Voting complete for banner - Invite student delegation on the Words Matter initiative - Chad said the intermediate department is discussing helping the kids with empathy and understanding the difference between teasing and insulting - Tara mentioned a health pilot that she asked for funding for GoZen earlier in the year (mindfulness, anxiety, wellness modules). There is a specific one about how to stay connected with peers. That will be coming in, in the fall. - Superintendent email about zero tolerance for an identity related insulted, this is based on the student fully understanding what they were saying. Any use of these words is to be reported to admin. Looking at educating kids to make sure that they fully understand the context and harm of these terms. -	5 mins	Council Members
14	Adjournment		

Notes:
MOE – Ontario Ministry of Education
PIC – Parent Involvement Committee (https://www.wrdsb.ca/pic/)
PRO – Parents Reaching Out
SCIS – Safe, Caring & Inclusive Schools (https://www.wrdsb.ca/pic/links/safe-caring-and-inclusive-schools-scis-resources/)
WRAPSC – Waterloo Region Assembly of Public School Councils (https://www.wrdsb.ca/our-schools/get-involved/wrapsc/)

General Council Email: silverheightscouncil@gmail.com

WRAPSC Update April 2023

OSSTF

- Online learning outcomes from the pandemic: far from optimal way to teach students: most kids lack the self discipline, a small portion thrived
    - Social and behaviour problems
        - Serious violence
            - Teachers not allowed to intervene; some teachers have been physically assaulted trying to save a child from harm
            - Bathroom damage (stall doors ripped off by students)
                - Schools responded with a major reset on rules; some have worked well
                - How can parents help: support your students being involved at school (clubs, etc); parent volunteering requires supervision at school now
- Blended Learning
    - Ministry sets out a certain number of days for professional development. Most of those are already designated for certain purposes. When something new comes along, they need additional days ie. de-streaming, which is a massive change. Need a whole lot of time to consider how to handle it. They can't add more professional development days, so they offer blended learning to split the day.
        - Will these days end? May continue next year as destreaming is still continuing, not sure.
- Not all clubs and activities have returned since the pandemic began

OK2BME

- School board supported
- Available for youth under 29. Over 12, do not need parental consent. Under 16 try to get parental involvement.
- Youth group on Tuesdays
- Will come to schools (for free) and speak to whole classes or individuals; they would prefer not to come back and forth for one class on one day and another on another day, want to help classes in school on one day
- Sexual education for LGBTQ youth isn't in the curriculum ie. protection, testing, etc.
    - It's an issue in all levels of education.
    - Some teachers don't know how to teach it. In some cases, students had to teach some pieces.
- Canadian student sexuality: 39% are LGBQ+ (encompasses gay, lesbian, bisexual, pansexual, queer, and other). Bisexual is the largest category 16% of LGBQ+
    - Survey: 62% 2SLGBTQ respondents feel unsafe at school, compared to 11% of cisgender heterosexual students
    - Survey: 64% of all participants reported hearing homophobic comments daily or weekly at school
- Frequency of sexist or transphobic comments: negative remarks or not being masculine or feminine enough, or outright insults about cisgender girls, cisgender boys, or trangender. 45% cisgender girls had daily negative remarks. 9% transgender had outright insults daily.
- Canadian student gender identity: 6% are non-binary, 4% are trans, 2% are gender fluid, 2% are gender queer (encompasses non-binary, MTF, FTM, trans boy/man, trans girl/woman, feel like a girl sometimes, feel like a boy sometimes, two spirit, intersex, gender queer, gender-fluid, gender-creative, bi-gender, other)
    - 0.33% of Canadians are trangender or non-binary

Scott Millar:

- All school policies are on the board's website. All policies should be system wide. https://www.wrdsb.ca/about-the-wrdsb/policiesprocedures/policies/
- Board hierarchy: Discuss concerns first with the teacher, and if you want to discuss further, reach out to the principal, and then the superintendent.
    - Issues for parents doing this: damages relationships. School councils would rather it go through WRAPSC, so it doesn't put a parent in the center.
- Vast inconsistencies between schools: possible cause: most principals weren't principals outside of the pandemic
- Confusion among council reps about what is a WRDSB board decision vs school. All board policies are on the website. https://www.wrdsb.ca/about-the-wrdsb/policiesprocedures/policies/
- Possibly some decisions by the board should be shared to system leaders like the chairs of the schools
- Desire for board policies on Grade 8 celebrations and field trips to be related directly to system leaders; councils are confused about what is a board vs school level decision. The school councils want consistency in what they are allowed to do.
    - Issues of consistency: some schools benefit from being allowed to do an event; to others, it is harmful
    - Grade 8 celebrations are a school's choice
        - Category 3 field trips (out of province): aren't allowed by the board
        - Category 2 field trips (overnight field trips): are not allowed by the board unless the school already started to organize one in the fall of 2022; however, going forward, this won't be allowed.
- Concerns about the expense of police checks for volunteers
- Best Practices Survey of School Councils (largest response ever):
    - Relationship with admin: 42.5% great, 22.5% average, 22.5% average, and 15% poor.
    - Admin's working relationship with council: 42.5% great, 22.5% above avg, 22.5% avg, 12.5 % poor
    - How long principal has been at your school? > 3 yrs 27.5%, 2-3 yrs 35%, 1-2 yrs 20%, 6 months-1 yr 10%, under 6 months 10%
    - Challenges with admin: communication on staffing issues, understanding the community, newness to job, no fun for kids allowed, selective in spending council funds, doesn't listen to parents, frequent principal change every 2 months, using council funds for school supplies when school budget runs out, purchasing items council feels should be covered by the board, too strict, clear communication, not building trust, misaligned goals, trying to run council, skipping council meetings, objecting to council initiatives, not supportive with issues, does not support or uplift women, no clear guidance on types of fundraising and activities are allowed at school, not responding to council's emails, not allowing council to pay for requested items that should fall under council's umbrella
    - What has worked well dealing with admin: open communication, honesty, finding ways to hold activities that don't require supervision or extra work for teachers, calling the principal or vp with concerns, talking about things well in advance, putting plans in writing and following up regularly, communication.
    - What councils want from admin: strong relationships, better communication, clarity, action, planning, more respect, not telling councils what to do, more clarification about school events to parents in general ie. parents are given less info than before the pandemic, transparency about funds used in the classroom, openness,

cooperation based on mutual respect, open minded exchange, open and honest communication, more freedom, more interest in school's low EQAO scores, greater collaboration, transparency, clear goals that the school is working on to improve learning and council being able to support that, valuing council's thinking and creativity, allowing student representation.

WRAPSC/PIC bridging update

- PRO grants: schools might like to group together to get more expensive presenters
- trustee rep: talked about a request to provide all secondary school students with free city bus passes. This will need lots of help from the community groups and will be looked into.
- Have had over 70 applications for the PRO grant in the region by schools

WRDSB Psychology Series

- https://www.wrdsb.ca/blog/2023/04/03/april-lunch-and-learn-sessions-for-parents-and-caregivers-3/
- "Social Media and Technology Use for Teens"
  - When: April 26, 2023 from 12:15 to 12:45 p.m.

EVENTS (AP):

Explore Your Future Series:

- Cambridge April 13 from 5-8 pm. Free. Sign up is necessary. https://explorewaterloo.ca/event/explore-your-future-cambridge-2023/
- https://www.eventbrite.ca/e/explore-your-future-cambridge-2023-exhibitor-re-registration-537637306657
  - Explore Your Future offers an opportunity for local employers, businesses, and educational institutions to inform youth and their parents/guardians about the many employment, education, and career exploration opportunities in Waterloo Region.
  - Event Audience:
    Grade 7-12 students and their parents/guardians (900 registered in 2019)
    Educators from across Waterloo Region
    Representatives from over 75 regional organizations
- Kitchener May 17 from 5-8 pm. Free. Sign up is necessary. See the Cambridge event for specifics.
  https://explorewaterloo.ca/event/explore-your-future-kitchener-2023/
  https://www.eventbrite.ca/e/explore-your-future-kitchener-2023-exhibitor-registration-registration-539735793287

- WRDSB Psychology series just hosted a "Social Media and Technology Use for Teens" talk. They recommended a couple of books. See the links.

  RAISING HUMANS IN A DIGITAL WORLD: HELPING KIDS BUILD A HEALTHY RELATIONSHIP WITH TECHNOLOGY BY DIANA GRABER
  https://www.chapters.indigo.ca/en-ca/books/raising-humans-in-a-digital/9780814439791-item.html?ikwid=raising+humans+in+a+digital+world&ikwsec=Home&ikwidx=0#algoliaQueryId=cfe989ff7ef6a340ed82e74a39e5fcfa
  BEHIND THEIR SCREENS: WHAT TEENS ARE FACING (AND ADULTS ARE MISSING)
  by Emily Weinstein, Carrie James
  https://www.chapters.indigo.ca/en-ca/books/behind-their-screens-what-teens/9780262047357-item.html?ikwid=behind+their+screens&ikwsec=Home&ikwidx=0#algoliaQueryId=1557002f4ab3c396576c8209af54ff4a

Also, for the next WRAPSC meeting, all the WRAPSC reps will be meeting with all of the trustees. There will be an opportunity to discuss any of the policies seen in the link below with them. Is there anything that our council would like me to bring up?

https://www.wrdsb.ca/about-the-wrdsb/policiesprocedures/policy-review/

There is also an upcoming **Explore Your Future event for Grades 7-12 and their parents**. All of the major universities and colleges are there (U of W, U of Guelph, Conestoga College, Fanshawe College, Wilfred Laurier, etc), various trade opportunities (woodworking, machine operators, etc), Loblaws, firefighter, City of Cambridge, YMCA, a bank, Specialist High Skills Majors, Volunteer Waterloo Region, etc. Students can ask questions of the exhibitors and pick up pamphlets. There are also a few talks. Good event! It is free, but you must sign up. https://www.eventbrite.ca/e/explore-your-future-kitchener-2023-registration-542992203297

Wed, May 17, 2023 5:00 PM - 8:00 PM EDT

Location: **The Aud** 400 East St Kitchener, ON N2H 1Z6

Also, WRDSB Psychology series has an upcoming talk called: Social Media and Technology Use for Teens

When: April 26, 2023 from 12:15 to 12:45 p.m.

https://erl.wrdsb.ca/2023/04/03/april-lunch-and-learn-sessions-for-parents-and-caregivers-2/

Volunteering and Certification - Tips from a parent based on her two teens' experience:

Best source to find volunteer opportunities for teens in our region: Volunteer Waterloo Region https://volunteerwr.ca/index.php?MenuItemID=179

- Filter for age.
- Keep checking back weekly for more opportunities for younger teens. They are more posted about every week, but there are only so many for ages 13-15.
- For a volunteer opportunity that lasts for several months (not all of the opportunities on their site are long like this), Volunteer Waterloo Region's recommendation to teens is to gather their friends together, and they can then take turns to complete the longer volunteering opportunity so that an individual teen doesn't have to volunteer as often (if they don't want to)
- Parent tip: I emailed my teens the opportunities that I found on this site and on other websites. Then, my teens contacted the places directly. Volunteer Waterloo Region has the volunteer events' contact info included in their postings.

Some of my teens' experience with volunteering in the region:

- Food4 Kids: good experience, though this place does not have as many volunteering opportunities available for young teens. They have some. https://food4kidswr.ca/volunteering/
- Political parties: taught them door-to-door techniques, dealing with rude adults at the door, the adults from their volunteering team made them feel like they belonged, gave my teen a sense of community.
    - Could get a lot of hours this way.
    - Best way to sign up: Show up at their office and ask. Don't email or call; I never got any responses this way.
- Rib Fest Cambridge & Guelph: they loved this one! This is a longer event and they can collect more hours.
    - Cambridge: https://cambridgeribandbeerfest.com/CAMBRIDGE-RIBFEST-Home.htm
    - Guelph: https://www.ribfestguelph.com/event-listing/guelph-ribfest-volunteer-sign-up
- Cambridge and Guelph Canada Day celebrations: they offer a lot of hours at one time; my oldest loved these.
    - Cambridge: https://www.cambridge.ca/en/your-city/Volunteer.aspx
    - Guelph: https://rotaryguelph.ca/stories/canada-day-2022#:~:text=The%20Rotary%20Club%20of%20Guelph's,Join%20the%20fun!
- The Museum: very boring to volunteer at, but they had lots of hours available every week.
- Silverheights' Neighbourhood Association and Hespeler Neighbourhood Association: close by and you don't have to drive your kids all over the region as much to get volunteering opportunities. My teens biked to Hespeler Neighbourhood Association and walked to Silverheights'.
    - Volunteering for their summer camps allows your teen to collect a lot of hours.
    - Your teen can gain various certifications for free. Read the certification section in this document for more info.
    - The Guidance office at your local high school will share many volunteer opportunities with your teens. You will also see some rarely in your weekly Google Classroom updates.

- However, my teens never used those opportunities. They liked the ones that I emailed from Volunteer Waterloo Region and the other places I listed above.

Tip: One of my teens enjoyed doing larger events and longer hours at a time. My other teen, at first, wanted to do many events that were frequently shorter in duration. However, when he was around 14, he started to want longer volunteering experiences ie. entire weeks helping at summer camp because he knew that his time to volunteer was going to be limited when he got his first job at 15.

Volunteering helps with jobs, scholarships for university, etc:

- Various scholarships for university are available if your teen volunteers. The more they volunteer, the more likely they are to get the scholarship. If you have access to *The Scholarship Report* (Jacob Hespeler Secondary's school council pays for it for their students -- so far each year), then you can check out the criteria for various scholarships available in Ontario. https://seekingscholarships.com/the-scholarship-report/
- Volunteering helped with getting my teen's job at McDonalds, personal contacts helped as well. The interviewer became quite excited when he saw my son's hours. She hired him on the spot.
- Volunteering helps get your teen the best on-campus jobs at university (talk that I attended)
- Increases the likelihood of admission to teacher's college if your child switches from a 4 year degree at a local university instead of starting with concurrent education; universities select people based on the most volunteering
- Volunteering as an assistant lifeguard helps you get a city job as a lifeguard/swim instructor https://www.google.com/search?q=city+of+cambridge+lifeguard+jobs&rlz=1C1SQJL_enCA865CA865&oq=city+of+cambridge+lifeguard+jobs&aqs=chrome..69i57j0i22i30l3.6847j0j7&sourceid=chrome&ie=UTF-8&ibp=htl;jobs&sa=X&ved=2ahUKEwjGtNqTvab-AhWukIkEHbqxD88Qkd0GegQIFRAB#fpstate=tldetail&htivrt=jobs&htiq=city+of+cambridge+lifeguard+jobs&htidocid=6Yw0yL7BRfYAAAAAAAAAA%3D%3D&sxsrf=APwXEdckA_9sxIJ505yT_NkMFrUWmNwLxQ:1681375853195

Tip: Getting started volunteering ASAP (as soon as teen is done Gr 8) because some teens will choose to start working at 15 (my teen's experience), and some jobs at 14 (other people's experience). It is harder to juggle school, working, and volunteering all together, especially if they are in the IB program at Glenview (other people's experience). Also, your teens will need those hours to graduate high school.

Tip: How to keep volunteering affordable: My teens did not have data on their phones, so they emailed me (when they had Wi-Fi service) when they were done at a volunteering event. If they didn't have Wi-Fi service available, they asked another volunteer to call us to say that they needed to be picked up. Some volunteering events have unpredictable end times.

Other examples of volunteering opportunities:

- Idea Exchange: sign up for volunteering is possibly still really early. Sign up in Jan/Feb for the upcoming summer
- Possible volunteering to be a tutor: Kinbridge. chadm@kinbridge.ca
- Carizon volunteering 16+: Email: kmcarthur@carizon.ca Apply: volgistics.com/appform/1744906274

Certifications your teen can acquire for Grades 7-10:

- Lead certificate: **free** at HVNA by volunteering at summer camp
- Silverheights Neighbourhood Association (SNA): Lead certification was offered in the past, you can check for availability (as early as Grade 7, I think)
- SNA: High Five **free** certification to volunteers (Grade 8+, ask if you can get at younger ages)
- CPRC + AED from St. John's Ambulance (can take as early as the first semester of Grade 10) https://www.sja.ca/en/first-aid-training/cpr-c-aed?
    - need this for lifeguard certification (teens might have all their lifeguard and swim instructor training completed by the age of 15)
    - helpful knowledge for the future to have as a parent
- Leader in Training Camp (ages 13-16 volunteers) through the city: can get certified through High Five and Standard First Aid & CPRC https://www.cambridge.ca/en/parks-recreation-culture/Camps.aspx
- Some city jobs for students require High Five and at least Standard First Aid & CPRC certifications ie. a lifeguard and a swim instructor: https://www.google.com/search?q=city+of+cambridge+lifeguard+jobs&rlz=1C1SQJL_enCA865CA865&oq=city+of+cambridge+lifeguard+jobs&aqs=chrome..69i57j0i22i30l3.6847j0j7&sourceid=chrome&ie=UTF-8&ibp=htl;jobs&sa=X&ved=2ahUKEwjGtNqTvab-AhWukIkEHbqxD88Qkd0GegQIFRAB#fpstate=tldetail&htivrt=jobs&htiq=city+of+cambridge+lifeguard+jobs&htidocid=6Yw0yL7BRfYAAAAAAAAAAA%3D%3D&sxsrf=APwXEdckA_9sxIJ505yT_NkMFrUWmNwLxQ:1681375853195